

The Drapaudi Ratha, with a curved roof that mimics thatch, one of five rock-cut monoliths known as the Pancha Rathas, or ‘Five Chariots’, at Mahabalipuram (Mamallapuram). From an album of photographs taken by an unnamed photographer in the 1860s.

The *Periplus* also refers to two local rulers, ‘the elder Saraganus’ and ‘Sandares’. The first name probably refers to Satakarni I and the second to Sundara Satakarni, the twentieth ruler on the *Matsya Purana*’s list of Satavahana kings, who ruled very briefly in about 50 CE – a link that helps to date the Indian information in the *Periplus* as gathered very soon after that year.

The *Periplus* reinforces the archaeological and numismatic evidence, which shows that the Satavahanas took over control of both the interior and coastal trades of the Deccan just at the time when the Romans discovered the secret of the shifting monsoon trade winds. With the Roman takeover of the Ptolemaic kingdom of Egypt in 30 BCE the Eritrean Sea became accessible to Roman shipping, opening the way for maritime trade with India on a grand scale.

In 1507 a well-known antiquarian in the European city of Augsburg named Konrad Peutinger was shown eleven sheets of a parchment scroll which when joined together